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Understanding the associations between social media marketing and green outcomes: A study of employee green behavior

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ABSTRACT

Guided by the Knowledge Attitude Behavior Theory, the current study examines the interdependences among social media green marketing (SMGM), receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM), green attitude (GAT), voluntary green behavior (VGB), and green electronic word-of-mouth (GEW). In addition, the mediating role of green attitude between these variables is also examined in this study. Data were collected from 301 employees working in various organizations. Findings indicated a significant correlation exists among SMGM, RSMM, and VGB, and SMGM alone was found to have a positive correlation with GAT and GEW.

Furthermore, GAT shows a positive correlation with VGB and GEW. The mediation analysis indicated that GAT mediates the relationship between SMGM and these factors. This study contributes new insights into how employees' social media usage influences their environmentally supportive attitudes, behaviors, and word-of-mouth conversations. Organizational stakeholders can integrate social media green marketing into their everyday operations to inspire pro-environmental behavior within the workplace.

1. Introduction

Several organizations share their sustainability efforts with stakeholders. Previous research indicates that social media platforms are used to raise awareness about environmental sustainability (Hamid et al., 2017), promote health awareness (Lapointe et al., 2014), enhance understanding of wildlife conservation (Wu et al., 2018), and conduct campaigns to encourage sustainable practices (Scholtz et al., 2016). Social media facilitates sustainability activities and expands organizational stakeholder relationships in novel ways (Hamid et al., 2017; Sakka & Ahammad, 2020). In addition, organizations have increasingly exploited social media platforms to facilitate their sustainability efforts. The 2023 digital report further states that 59.4 percent of the global population uses social media for various purposes. Further, it found that 41.4 percent of employees around the world use platforms like enterprise social media to support organizational activities.

However, previous research lacks substantial empirical evidence regarding the influence of green marketing on social media and the acceptance of green messages related to voluntary green behavior in the workplace. A thorough literature review uncovers the following gaps: (a) while studies have investigated the use of social media to raise awareness and encourage engagement with environmental issues (Han et al., 2025; Japutra et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2023), the specific use of social media messaging to promote responsible green behavior in work settings remains largely unexamined (Ng et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2023). This gap should be researched because knowledge precedes behavioral change. Existing studies, such as Tandon et al. (2023), identify such behaviors. Organizations have also actively adopted social media technologies to support sustainability initiatives (Hamid et al., 2017). However, there is a lack of research on how the use of social media for green marketing influences green attitudes, employee green behavior, and e-word of mouth. (b) At the same time, some earlier studies have examined the effects of social media on employee engagement and green behavior (e.g., Ewing et al., 2019; Ng et al., 2025), but the connection between employees' responsiveness to social media messages and their green attitudes, behaviors, and e-word of mouth remains unclear. The manner in which receivers use social media and their attitudes towards it significantly affect whether messages are received and understood. This gap warrants investigation. (c) Although the connection between attitude and behavior in human-technology interactions and pro-environmental actions is thoroughly explored (Aslan et al., 2025; Pandey et al., 2025), the relationship between attitude and voluntary green behavior in the workplace, as well as green electronic word-of-mouth, remains under-researched. Since social media green marketing aims to inspire employees to adopt green behaviors and encourage them to influence others, addressing this gap is

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critical.

In summary, we argue that there is a lack of understanding regarding the factors affecting the impact of social media green marketing (SMGM) and receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM) on green attitudes and, consequently, on voluntary green behavior and green electronic word-of-mouth. Our study addresses these gaps by posing the following research questions: RQ1: How do social media green marketing (SMGM) and receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM) impact employees' green attitudes (GAT), voluntary green behavior (VGB), and green electronic word-of-mouth (GEW)? RQ2: Does GAT mediate the relationship between SMGM, RSMM, VGB, and GEW?

Drawing on Knowledge Attitude Behavior Theory (Kallgren & Wood, 1986), we construct and analyze a theoretical model based on data from 301 employees. The key findings of this research can be summarized as follows. Firstly, this study represents one of the first comprehensive examinations of the influence of underexplored factors such as social media green marketing (SMGM) and its receptivity (RSMM) on employees' green attitude (GAT) and how these relate to voluntary green behaviors (VGB) in the workplace and their green electronic word-of-mouth (GEW). Secondly, an investigation into the relationship between GAT, VGB, and GEW contributes to the literature in a new way. While each relationship has been comparatively under-researched, each is theoretically and managerially significant. In general, this study provides an example for organizations on how social media could be used to promote green attitudes, encourage green behaviors, and engage in green electronic word-of-mouth for employees. We would like to notify you that the following abbreviations of the study constructs will be used throughout the subsequent sections: social media green marketing (SMGM), receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM), green attitude (GAT), voluntary green behavior (VGB), and green electronic word-of-mouth (GEW).

2. Theoretical background

2.1. Knowledge attitude behavior theory (KAB)

The KAB theory explains how knowledge, attitude, and behavior relate to one another. According to the KAB theory, having the needed information or experience will influence someone's attitude toward a subject (Kallgren & Wood, 1986). Through the KAB theory, knowledge shows how knowledge affects behaviors (e.g., Dhir, Talwar, et al., 2021) and attitudes (Kemm,1995). The KAB theory has been applied across various fields to clarify behaviors resulting from the interplay of knowledge and attitudes. For example, it has been utilized to investigate green apparel purchasing behavior (Dhir, Talwar, et al., 2021), acceptance of innovative technologies (Krishen et al., 2025), intentions to buy sustainable clothing (Huang et al., 2024), tourism-related sustainable attitudes and behaviors (Walsh & Dodds, 2022), and eco-friendly behaviors among university students (Núñez-Tabales et al., 2024).

KAB helps illustrate the influence of knowledge on pro-environmental behavior choices (Huang et al., 2024; Sharma & Chhikara, 2023). Therefore, this study utilizes the KAB model to explore employees' behaviors and attitudes towards sustainability. As shown in Fig. 1, SMGM and RSMM are sources of experience and knowledge that affect GAT. They also influence VGB and GEW, representing behavior directly and through GAT. Our research, as far as we know, is the first to combine these variables in an attempt to measure word-of-mouth and employees' green behavior.

3. Hypotheses development

3.1. Social media green marketing, green attitude, voluntary green behavior, and green electronic word of mouth

Social marketing through social media has also worked to influence people. Programs like "A Walk Can Work Wonders" (Bauman et al., 2024) are evidence of its success and effectiveness. In the same vein, social media also influences technology, as can be seen from its influence on perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness of metaverse technology for hotel booking (Ahmad et al., 2024). Moreover, as Muhammad et al. (2024) discovered in Islamic banks have been a center of marketing efforts. Moreover, social media significantly raises awareness for socially conscious causes, such as encouraging organ donation (Ahmed et al., 2025).

Digital marketing channels significantly improve awareness of green practices, increase product purchases, and encourage eco-friendly lifestyles (Alamsyah et al., 2020; Do Paco et al., 2019; Zubair et al., 2020).

This effect raises questions about the extent to which social media marketing can be used to engage employees. Although few findings exist regarding the influence of social media marketing on employees' intentions, attitudes, and work-related behaviors, previous studies have investigated the outcomes of technology usage in the workplace and its effects. For example, new technology adoption promotes flexibility and generates autonomy (Allen & Shoard, 2005; Yamane & Kaneko, 2021), enabling users, for example, employees, to distribute and edit various content on the Internet (Ruparel et al., 2020).

Previous literature indicates that firms increasingly utilize social media to promote green consumption and increase their exposure to green activities (e.g., Giacomini et al., 2020). Additionally, green message advertisement influences consumers' attitudes and intentions (e.g., Machado & de Andrés, 2023). Similarly, the literature indicates that green advertising influences environmental attitudes (Vafaei-Zadeh et al., 2025). In this instance, firms' green marketing on social media (SMGM) is most likely to have an influence on employees' green attitudes (GAT). This expectation is supported by prior findings regarding employees, where practices such as green training in human resources

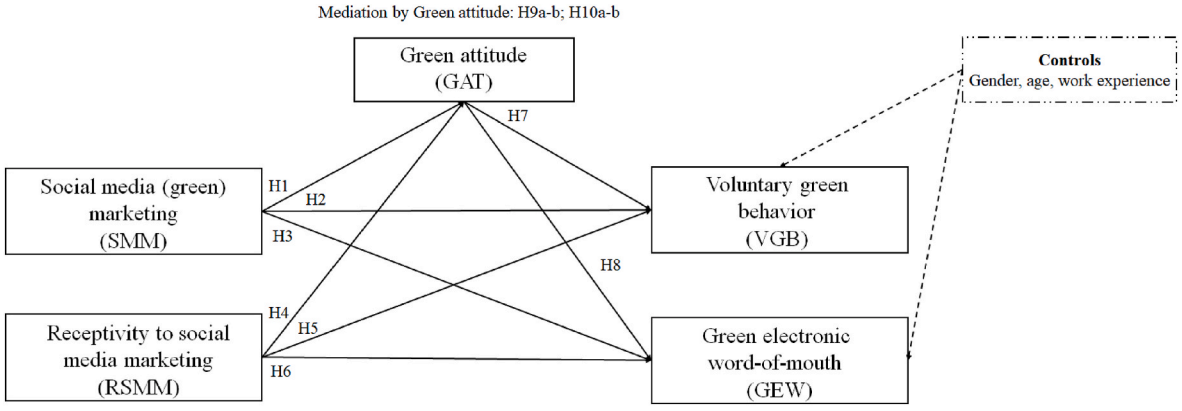


Fig. 1. Conceptual model.

have been shown to influence employees' GAT (e.g., AlKetbi & Rice, 2024).

KAB model indicates the knowledge attitude relationship (Kallgren & Wood, 1986; Sharma & Chhikara, 2023) to represent the part played by knowledge in positive or negative attitude creation (Dhir, Talwar, et al., 2021). Hence, we hypothesize.

H1. Firms' SMGM is positively related to employees' GAT

Previous research highlights that the application of interactive content and bespoke marketing allows organizations to create a virtual environment that fosters awareness of sustainable practices and encourages collective commitment to environmental stewardship (Berraies et al., 2020; Martín-Rojas et al., 2020). Based on this argument, as social media marketing is effective and cost-effective (Du et al., 2015; Kumar et al., 2016), firms can utilize it to promote green behaviors in the workplace.

Furthermore, in alignment with existing literature that suggests green initiatives by firms encourage consumers to share positive word-of-mouth (WOM) about these efforts (e.g., Lin et al., 2024), it can be reasonably argued that companies' green marketing on social media may motivate employees to voice positive opinions regarding environmentally friendly workplace actions. Given that social media serves as the medium for green marketing, it is likely that employees will also participate in sharing green WOM on these platforms. This introduces a relatively recent concept called GEW (Huu-Hoang Nguyen et al., 2024; Huy et al., 2022).

Through the KAB lens, we assert that enhanced environmental knowledge fosters awareness for making informed green choices (Wang et al., 2018). SMGM is a source of knowledge that can influence employees' values towards green behavior (VGB) and green employee wellness (GEW). This perception aligns with green human resources management literature focusing on green training and development to facilitate environmentally friendly behavior (Farrukh et al., 2022; Judeh & Khader, 2023). Therefore, green marketing by a company on social media can inspire employees' eco-friendly behavior within the workplace and cause them to post positive news regarding workplace environmental activities through social media. Therefore, we hypothesize.

H2. Firms' SMGM is positively related to employees' VGB at the workplace

H3. Firms' SMGM is positively related to employees' GEW at the workplace

3.2. Receptivity to social media marketing, green attitude, voluntary green behavior, and green electronic word-of-mouth

Using personal social media impacts both organizational and personal lives, allowing users to share information about issues with their networks and connect with them (Brooks, 2015; Dhir et al., 2018, 2019). Regarding sustainability practices, this decentralized and grassroots information sharing empowers individuals to engage more actively in environmental discussion (Cuypers et al., 2020).

Employees who engage with information about sustainability enhance their awareness and help shape a collective consciousness regarding eco-friendly living (Al-Swidi et al., 2021; Al-Ghazali & Afsar, 2021). This raises an important question about their receptiveness to green communications and the messages being conveyed to them, much like in consumer contexts (Bailey et al., 2016). This aspect is a necessity to factor in for companies looking to tailor their environmental messages on social media to their workers. Previous studies indicate that while green marketing resonates with environmentally conscious consumers (Zabkar & Hosta, 2013), it is questionable whether all employees, particularly those with less environmental concerns, will be equally receptive to receiving such messages.

Technology integration enables workers to contribute significantly toward making an organization work toward a more sustainable and satisfying way of working (Giotis & Papadionysiou, 2022). Furthermore, workplace engagement of workers with social media generates a sustainable, green, and technology-backed workplace culture (Wesselink et al., 2017). The environmental sensitiveness of social media content generates a sense of purpose and fulfillment among employees that comes from making the world a more sustainable place (Arkema et al., 2021). Thus, it is crucial to understand how Receptivity to Social Media Messages (RSMM) affects their green practice propensity.

Specifically, employees' responsiveness to green messaging encompasses their emotional attitudes, reactions, and attention levels toward the firms' green communications (Wu & Long, 2024). This information is significant, particularly when considering various factors, such as consumers' perceptions of greenwashing, which have been studied to analyze their reactions to green messages (Fernandes et al., 2020; Szabo & Webster, 2021).

Based on KAB theory, employees' willingness to learn through social media will likely foster a positive green attitude at work. Although this relationship has not been explored in the past for employees, aligned with the studies that consider receptivity important (Bailey et al., 2016), we propose to examine the association between RSMM and GAT. Examining this association might also help clarify the association since, in the broader literature, environmental signals-attitude link has not always been found to be relevant (Montoro-Rios et al., 2008). We therefore hypothesize the following.

H4. Employees' RSMM is positively related to their GAT

ICT usage enables the co-creation of brand-related online information (We Are Social, 2018). In addition to increasing awareness, the constant flow of inspiring and educational information fosters a feeling of purpose, a connection to the natural world, and fulfillment from being a part of a more significant movement towards sustainable living (Bauer, 2022), affecting behavior. Prior studies also suggested that online brand-related messages impact consumer behavior (e.g., Talwar et al., 2023) that may be related to sustainability activities, products, and services (Stockheim et al., 2024; Wong et al., 2020). In the broader consumer behavior literature, scholars suggest that green communication or advertising aims to affect green intention/behavior (Rahbar & Wahid, 2011) and that the receptivity of green communication or advertising are relevant in this effect (Sun et al., 2021). This also implies that if consumers are skeptical or less convincing (D'souza & Taghian, 2005; Furlow, 2010), they will be less receptive, which could affect their green behavior. Since employees' green behavior is helpful for the environment (Islam et al., 2022), understanding the effect of receptivity on VGB and GEW is useful. We therefore hypothesize.

H5. Employees' RSMM is positively related to their VGB at the workplace

H6. Employees' RSMM is positively related to their GEW at the workplace

3.3. Green attitude, voluntary green behavior, and green electronic word of mouth

Building on the previous discussion, we can assert that attitudes influence behavior in the consumer behavior literature and the KAB framework (Homer & Kahle, 1988; Kallgren & Wood, 1986). Additionally, prior research indicates that green attitude (GAT), which reflects an individual's assessment of green products, can lead to either positive or negative consequences (Verma et al., 2019), i.e., actual behavior (Zhang & Dong, 2020). Furthermore, studies show that attitude also affects word of mouth (Lee et al., 2023). In such a case, since we are proposing two positive outcomes, VGB and GEW, it can be possible to expect the GAT of employees to direct both outcomes.

H7. Employees' GAT is positively related to their VGB at the workplace

H8. Employees' GAT is positively related to employees' GEW at the workplace

In addition to GAT's direct influence on the intention to purchase green products (Olfat, M., 2025), the mediating role of attitude is also acknowledged (e.g., Jacobs et al., 2018; Wang et al., 2022). However, previous studies related to consumers reveal limited clarity on how knowledge impacts intentions and behavior (e.g., Sinha & Annamdevula, 2025). Some findings suggest that environmental knowledge does not directly affect behavior (e.g., Wang et al., 2018), while others indicate a significant correlation (e.g., Shanmugam et al., 2022). Given that KAB offers a valuable framework for examining the interaction between knowledge, attitude, and behavior (e.g., Dhir, Talwar, et al., 2021), we investigate not only the direct relationship but also the mediating role of attitude in the association of knowledge (coming from SMGM and deepening due RSMM) with VGB and GEW, proposing.

H9a. Employees' GAT mediates the association of firms' SMGM and employees' VGB at the workplace

H9b. Employees' GAT mediates the association of firms' SMGM and employees' GEW at the workplace

H10a. Employees' GAT mediates the association of employees' RSMM and employees' VGB at the workplace

H10b. Employees' GAT mediates the association of employees' RSMM and employees' GEW at the workplace

4. Method

4.1. Data collection

The selected study population consisted of US workers to test the above assumptions. It is appropriate in our case for many reasons. In the first place, as an industrially advanced country with strong sensitization relating to environmental issues, US workers are better informed on environmental awareness, ecologic accountability, and sustainability concerns. Second, given that the US is the hub of social media platform innovation and engagement, both firms and employees are more inclined to utilize social media for a range of personal and professional activities.

We surveyed US-based employees as part of a cross-sectional study. In February 2025, we collected data through an English-language online survey using purposive and random sampling methods. A total of 301 employees provided their responses. According to Hair et al. (2019), the sample size should be approximately five times the number of items used for data analysis. We analyzed 19 items, suggesting a sample size of n = 95, but we used n = 301 responses for the final analysis. In the survey, where a five-point scale was employed, the author guaranteed respondents' anonymity and confidentiality to allow them to give honest feedback. The respondents' details are presented in Table 1.

4.2. Measures

SMGM has been assessed using five items by Logan et al. (2012) and Hynes and Wilson (2016). RSMM has been assessed using four items by Bailey et al. (2016) and Do Paco et al. (2019). Five of van Tonder et al.'s (2020) and Matthes & Wonneberger's (2014) scales have been adopted to measure GAT. VGB has then been measured with four items on Bissing-Olson et al.'s (2013) and Norton et al.'s (2014) part, and GEW has been measured with four items developed on the basis of Zeithaml et al. (1996).

Table 1
Respondent details.

Demographic	Classification	Frequency	Percentage
Gender	Female	79	26.25
	Male	222	73.75
Age	21–30 years	75	24.92
	31–40 years	97	32.23
	41–50 years	64	21.26
	51and above	65	21.59
Experience	≤ 10 years	99	32.89
	11–20 years	87	28.90
	≥ 21 years	115	38.21

4.3. Control variables

Previous studies have emphasized the confounding effect of gender, age, and other socio-demographic characteristics on sharing behavior in social media use (Cao et al., 2018). Against these issues, we controlled 'gender,' 'age,' and experience' to mitigate the confounding effect of such variables in the data analysis.

5. Analysis and results

Covariance-Based Structural Equation Modeling (CB-SEM) was applied to evaluate the research model proposed. Several reasons inform our choice of CB-SEM in this analysis. First, given our adequate sample size, CB-SEM offers comprehensive fit indices that assist in assessing the model's adequacy and robust parameter estimates, second, it is especially effective for analyzing complex models that contain latent variables (Al Issa & Abdelsalam, 2021; Cheah et al., 2020), and third, it is well-suited for theory testing and validation, enabling computation of the model fit indices and testing of hypotheses (Al Issa & Abdelsalam, 2021; Richter et al., 2016; Svensson, 2015), and finally, it is ideal for confirmatory research, where the primary aim is to test hypotheses derived from established theories (Richter et al., 2016; Svensson, 2015).

5.1. Common method bias

Podsakoff et al. (2003) discuss how studies employing self-reported measures are most susceptible to the threat of common method bias (CMB). However, Harman's single-factor test negated the presence of this threat, by showing that a single component explained 44.69 % covariance, within the threshold of 50 %. Second, comparing the fit indices of a five-factor and a single-factor CFA, we found that the single-factor test produced a poorer data fit. Thus, it is concluded that CMB does not affect the present research.

5.2. Construct's reliability and validity

The measurement model had an adequate fit (CMIN/DF = 2.088, CFI = 0.971, TLI = 0.965, SRMR = 0.056, RMSEA = 0.060). Next, we tested the measurement instrument for reliability. Values of Cronbach's Alpha and composite reliability above the recommended value > 0.70 indicated that the instrument had the recommended reliability (Hair et al., 2019). Moreover, factor loading and values of AVE were also significant (suggested cut-off of 0.50) (Tables 2 and 3).

We also assessed discriminant validity by examining inter-construct correlations alongside the square root of AVEs. The coefficients were found to be below the specified square root values (Table 3).

The "Heterotrait-Monotrait (HTMT)" ratio, a multitrait-multimethod matrix, is used as a final criterion to evaluate discriminant validity. The HTMT value is less than the threshold of 0.85 (Kline, 2011). The discriminant validity of the measurement model based on HTMT values has been established in Table 4.

5.3. Hypotheses testing

5.3.1. Direct path

We tested our hypotheses using CB-SEM. The results showed that none of the control variables had a confounding effect on the two outcome variables except for age which showed significant confounding

Table 2
Constructs items and factor loadings.

Items	CFA FL	SEM FL
Green attitude (GAT)		
GAT1	0.898	0.898
GAT2	0.930	0.930
GAT3	0.944	0.943
GAT4	Dropped	–
GAT5	Dropped	–
Green electronic word-of-mouth (GEW)		
GEW1	0.891	0.894
GEW2	0.903	0.904
GEW3	0.880	0.880
GEW4	0.820	0.813
Receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM)		
RSMM1	0.641	0.642
RSMM2	Dropped	–
RSMM3	0.870	0.871
RSMM4	0.818	0.814
Social media (green) marketing (SMM)		
SMGM1	0.892	0.892
SMGM2	0.912	0.912
SMGM3	0.909	0.909
SMGM4	0.805	0.804
SMGM5	Dropped	–
Voluntary green behavior (VGB)		
VGB1	0.901	0.900
VGB2	0.947	0.949
VGB3	0.927	0.927
VGB4	0.748	0.745

effect on only VGB ($\beta = 0.226$, $p = 0.047$). However, experience displayed confounding effect when tested using bootstrapping as the confidence interval did not contain zero ($\beta = -0.219$, LLCI $= -0.393$, ULCI $= -0.046$), indicating that the experience had a significant effect on VGB. Fig. 2 and Table 5 show the results of the path analysis for direct paths. All hypotheses except H4 and H6 are supported. The model explained a 17.1 % variance in GAT, 27.2 % in GEW, and 28.0 % in VGB.

5.3.2. *Indirect path*

We tested the proposed mediation hypothesis to find support for some of the suggested indirect paths, as shown in Table 6.

6. Discussion

We investigated the relationships among SMGM, RSMM, GAT, VGB, and GEW. Additionally, this research examines GAT's mediating role in the in the association of SMGM and RSMM with VGB and GEW. We posed two research questions and formulated the relationships between the identified variables based on KAB theory. RQ1 explored how SMGM and RSMM impact employees' GAT, VGB, and GEW. The findings revealed that SMGM significantly positively affects employees' GAT. This statistically significant support agrees with prior extended literature on the effect of green advertising on attitudes (e.g., Machado & de Andrés, 2023; Vafaei-Zadeh et al., 2025). It indicates that social media advertising, as a source of green information, positively affects people's attitudes towards green and pro-environmental work behavior. It also suggests that higher exposure to environmental information via social media enhances support for and belief in the value of green and pro-environmental behavior in the workplace.

Similarly, the findings support a positive relationship between SMGM and VGB, as indicated by previous research (e.g., Farrukh et al., 2022; Judeh & Khader, 2023; Wang et al., 2018). This support indicates that social media marketing as a source of green and environment-related information influences employees to engage in voluntary pro-environmental behaviors at their respective workplaces. Such voluntary green behavior can take the form of attending non-mandatory environment-related events, participating in meetings on green initiatives meetings, and taking self-initiative to act in eco-friendly ways at work.

In another such finding, the results indicated a statistically significant positive correlation between SMGM and GEW, in line with existing research (e.g., Huu-Hoang Nguyen et al., 2024; Huy et al., 2022). This suggests that employees who consider social media marketing a valuable and convenient resource for information about green and environmental issues are likelier to recommend pro-environmental and green workplace behaviors electronically, i.e., on social media. Such digital word of mouth could include speaking positively about green behaviors, recommending them to anyone who is seeking advice on social media, and encouraging one's friends and relatives to behave in an eco-friendly manner at their respective workplaces.

We also examined the relationship between RSMM and GAT, VGB, and GEW. Among these associations, the link between RSMM and GAT, based on prior extensive literature (e.g., Bailey et al., 2016), lacks statistical support. This agrees with a part of the broader literature which has found that the impact of environmental signals on attitude is not relevant (e.g., Montoro-Rios et al., 2008). As this relationship has not been explored before in the employee setting, it is recommended to test it again before drawing any conclusions. Similarly, the connection between RSMM and GEW is not statistically supported and requires additional exploration.

In contrast, the RSMM-VGB association, proposed based on prior extended literature (Sun et al., 2021; D'souza & Taghian, 2005; Furlow, 2010) is supported. It means that employees who respond favorably and positively to information about green and environmental concerns shared through social media, pay attention to it, and consider it meaningful, are more likely to exhibit voluntary green behavior by attending environment-related events, and information sessions regarding green initiatives that are not mandatory but help my organization's image, and take the initiative to act in green and pro-environmental ways in their organization.

The findings also support the positive association of GAT, VGB, and GEW. This aligns with KAB's core proposition that attitudes influence behavior (Homer & Kahle, 1988; Kallgren & Wood, 1986), leading to

Table 4
Heterotrait-Monotrait (HTMT) ratio of correlations.

	SMM	RSMM	GAT	GEW	VGB
SMM					
RSMM	0.617				
GAT	0.417	0.29			
GEW	0.458	0.366	0.392		
VGB	0.455	0.445	0.421	0.636	

Table 3
Results of Cronbach's alpha (α), CR, and AVE values.

	α (items)	CR	AVE	SMM	RSMM	GAT	GEW	VGB
SMM	0.930 (4)	0.932	0.775	**0.881**				
RSMM	0.817 (3)	0.823	0.612	0.602***	**0.782**			
GAT	0.946 (3)	0.946	0.854	0.413***	0.261***	**0.924**		
GEW	0.925 (4)	0.928	0.763	0.464***	0.347***	0.376***	**0.874**	
VGB	0.931 (4)	0.934	0.782	0.426***	0.427***	0.369***	0.592***	**0.884**

Note: N = 301; $\sqrt{}$ of AVE is depicted diagonally; Correlation values are significant at 0.001 level.

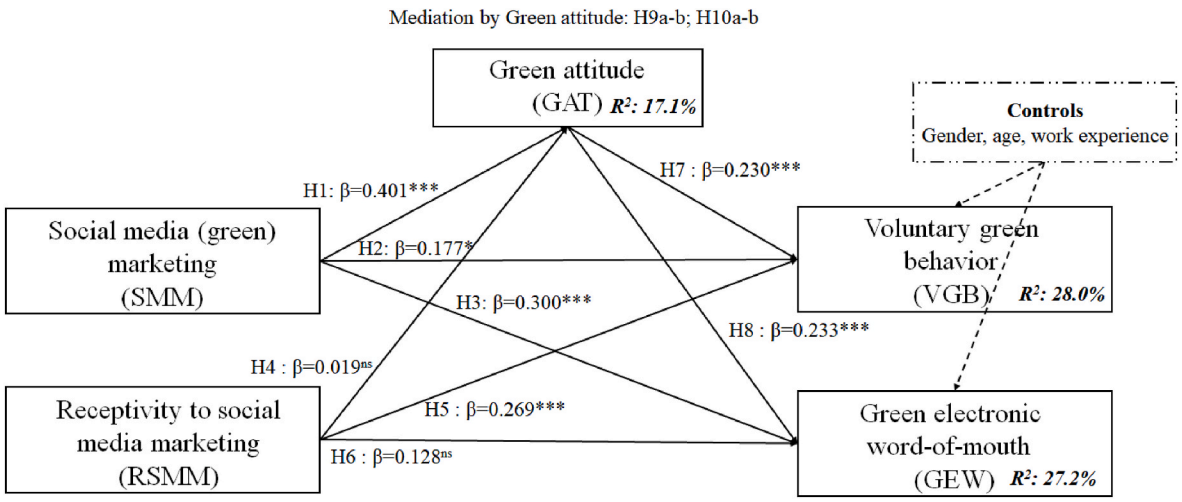


Fig. 2. Structural model.

Table 5
Path analysis.

Hypotheses	Path testing	Std β	t-statistics	p- values	Support
H1	SMGM → GAT	0.401	5.770	***	Supported
H2	SMGM → VGB	0.177	2.337	0.019	Supported
H3	SMGM → GEW	0.300	3.880	***	Supported
H4	RSMM → GAT	0.019	0.249	0.804	Not Supported
H5	RSMM → VGB	0.269	3.486	***	Supported
H6	RSMM → GEW	0.128	1.705	0.088	Not Supported
H7	GAT → VGB	0.230	3.844	***	Supported
H8	GAT → GEW	0.223	3.720	***	Supported

Table 6
Mediation analysis.

Hypotheses	Paths	Direct effect	Indirect effect	Total effect	Inference
H9a	SMGM → GAT → VGB	0.177^{ns}	0.092***	0.269**	Full Mediation
H9b	SMGM → GAT → GEW	0.300**	0.089**	0.390***	Partial Mediation
H10a	RSMM → GAT → VGB	0.269**	0.004^{ns}	0.273**	No Mediation
H10b	RSMM → GAT → GEW	0.128^{ns}	0.004^{ns}	0.132^{ns}	No effect

* Note The direct path from SMGM to VGB was significant in standard estimates ($\beta = 0.177$, $p < 0.05$), but when tested using bootstrapping, the confidence interval contained zero (LLCI = −0.017, ULCI = 0.337), so the effect was no longer significant.

positive or negative outcomes towards it (Verma et al., 2019; Zhang & Dong, 2020), word of mouth included (Lee et al., 2023). This means that employees who support green and pro-environmental behavior in the workplace and find value in these behaviors are more likely to voluntarily exhibit these behaviors in the workplace and also spread positive word of mouth about these behaviors on social media.

We then addressed RQ2, which asked about the mediational role of GAT between SMGM and RSMM on the one hand, and VGB and GEW on the other by extending existing literature (e.g., Jacobs et al., 2018; Wang et al., 2022). The result indicated statistical support for full mediation of GAT for path SMGM-GAT-VGB and partial mediation for path SMGM-GAT-GEW, confirming KAB's underlying view on the role of attitude.

7. Implications

7.1. Theoretical contributions

Our findings have three significant contributions to the literature. First, the present study proposed and empirically confirmed the influence of SMGM on GAT, VGB, and GEW. These are new relationships that have not been explored in the past in an employee context but are important to promote employee green behaviors and green recommendations. Having social media and electronic behavior as context is particularly meaningful since it is known that new technology use increases flexibility and feelings of autonomy (Allen & Shoard, 2005; Yamane & Kaneko, 2021). Also, since an increasing number of companies are using social media to promote sustainable consumption and make people aware of their green initiatives (e.g., Giacomini et al., 2020), it is natural to understand the impact of such activities on employees as well.

Second, we proposed and tested the influence of RSMM on GAT, VGB, and GEW. Since employees who interact with environmentally friendly information contribute to the shaping of a collective consciousness around sustainable living in addition to increasing awareness (Al-Swidi et al., 2021; Al-Ghazali & Afsar, 2021), an important question is how receptive they are to green communications and receiving the message conveyed to them, as asked in the case of consumers (Bailey et al., 2016). Understanding this aspect can be useful for firms wanting to target their green messages on social media for employees. This is a critical concern since past research in the consumer context has shown that while green marketing messages work well for consumers with environmental concerns (Zabkar & Hosta, 2013), are all, particularly employees with low environmental concerns, open to such messages?

We know that through digital connectivity, employees may significantly impact an organization's movement to promote a more sustainable and satisfying way of working (Giotis & Papadionysiou, 2022). However, since employees' use of social media provides a technological, sustainable, and environmental culture or approach at the workplace (Wesselink et al., 2017), and social media material that is environmentally sensitive fosters in the employees a sense of fulfillment and purpose that comes from making the world a more sustainable place (Arkema et al., 2021), it necessary to understand the role their receptivity of social media message plays in shaping their green inclination. In

other words, the effect of employees' receptivity to green communication refers to an emotional attitude, reaction, and the extent of attention towards green communication of firms (Wu & Long, 2024), which is important. Several factors, such as consumers' views on greenwashing, have been examined to understand their reaction to green communication (Fernandes et al., 2020; Szabo & Webster, 2021).

Finally, our research employs the KAB theory to help understand social media marketing and its receptivity as a source of green knowledge and how it affects green attitudes, voluntary green behavior, and electronic word of mouth. KAB is a novel lens for this setting, but it is suitable since knowledge/awareness is a key driver of responsible behavior. Using KAB, our study not only provides an apt theoretical background but also better reflects the knowledge economy beyond technology acceptance. By doing so, we also contribute to the expansion of KAB to a newer context and contribute to widening its acceptance as a key theoretical lens beyond existing applications (e.g., Dhir, Talwar, et al., 2021; Kallgren & Wood, 1986; Sharma & Chhikara, 2023).

7.2. Practical implications

This study offers three key practical implications: First, results returned a statistically significant association between SMGM and GAT; we recommend that while planning their SMGM strategies, firms should remember that these must also engage their employees. This will promote green behavior in the workplace and make it possible to be done cost-effectively, with social media marketing being effective and less costly (Du et al., 2015; Kumar et al., 2016). At the same time, SMGM was also found to impact behaviors, both VGB and GEW positively. Since the use of social media for green communication/marketing is effective in shaping employees' attitudes and behaviors, organizations and managers must plan to improve the content and perception of their green communication through social media. Here, training and development can be very important since the past literature on employees and green human resources practices, such as green training and development, has shown that such practices impact employees' attitudes (AlKetbi & Rice, 2024; Ren et al., 2018).

Second, the significant association of employees' RSMM with VGB is of greater significance to policy. Governments must create an environment that supports better receptivity to social media marketing because green behaviors are important globally and are not just limited to firms. Notably, the 2030 Agenda of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) recommends that organizations should invest in digital infrastructures and emphasize workplace digital transformation to help support organizational goals. It is also the responsibility of governments to support organizations.

Finally, recognizing the growing prominence and influence of social media and its growing use for green marketing on responsible green behavior in the workplace, governments can make it compulsory for all companies to use social media for this purpose. For this, the government can create a supportive environment by setting suitable regulations and competitive pricing policies to incentivize companies.

8. Limitations of the study and scope of future research

Although this study offers interesting insights based on empirical analysis, future researchers must acknowledge its limitations. The present research did not focus on potential diversity based on personalities and nationality in employees' RSMM and GAT. For this study, we collected data from a single country. Future studies may investigate the study variables from a multi-country perspective. Further, this study did not examine how SMGM affects other outcomes, such as green well-being and work engagement, and how they are connected to green self-efficacy. Also, this study used a cross-sectional survey; future research can use on a longitudinal, time-lagged or experimental design to better understand the evolving nature of the study variables. More studies are needed to investigate how technologies influence related outcomes based on the knowledge-based perspective, which has not received much scholarly attention.

9. Conclusion

To sum up, this study has explored the complex relationship between social media use for marketing, attitude towards the environment, and the influence that relationship has on green behavior and word of mouth of employees at the workplace. By means of an extensive analysis of extant literature in conjunction with empirical discoveries from our research, we have deciphered subtleties regarding how the virtual space of social media intersects with the tangible domains of sustainable behaviors.

However, our research recognizes that social media use requires a nuanced approach, considering potential issues including echo chambers, information overload, and the digital divide. Finding the right balance between virtual interaction and tangible effects is still a significant obstacle, underscoring the significance of focused interventions and calculated measures to optimize social media's beneficial effects on environmental consciousness and eco-friendly behavior.

Given the results of our research, we advise firms to consider integrating social media marketing into their sustainability plans. Targeted campaigns, online communities, and digital media can all be used to increase the impact of green attitudes and encourage people to act ecologically friendly in the workplace.

Appendix A1. Research Instrument

Social media green marketing (SMGM)

1. Social media marketing can provide me with timely information about green and environmental concerns
2. Social media marketing can provide me with effective information about green and environmental concerns
3. Social media marketing can provide me good source of up-to-date information about green and environmental concerns
4. Social media marketing is a convenient source of information for me about green and environmental concerns
5. The information about green and environmental concerns on social media is interesting to me.

Receptivity to social media marketing (RSMM)

1. I respond favorably to information about green and environmental concerns shared through social media
2. The use of social media for sharing information about green and environmental concerns affects me
3. I am the kind of person who responds positively to information about green and environmental concerns shared through social media
4. I think that information about green and environmental concerns shared through social media is meaningful

Green attitude (GAT)

1. I support green and pro-environmental behaviour in the workplace
2. I believe there is value in green and pro-environmental behaviour in the workplace
3. I believe it is worthwhile to have green and pro-environmental behaviour in the workplace
4. I feel proud when I show green and pro-environmental behaviour in the workplace
5. I have positive thoughts about green and pro-environmental behaviour in the workplace

Voluntary green behavior (VGB)

1. I attend environment-related events that are not mandatory but help my organization's image.
2. I attend information sessions regarding green initiatives that employees in my organization are encouraged but not required to attend.
3. I voluntarily attend and actively participate in green initiative meetings at my organization
4. I take the initiative to act in green and pro-environmental ways in my organization

Green electronic word of mouth (GEW)

1. I will say positive things about green and pro-environmental behaviour in workplace to other people on social media.
2. I will recommend green and pro-environmental behaviour in their workplace to someone who seeks advice on social media.
3. I will encourage friends and relatives through social media to do green and pro-environmental behaviour in their workplace

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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